

BEAVER

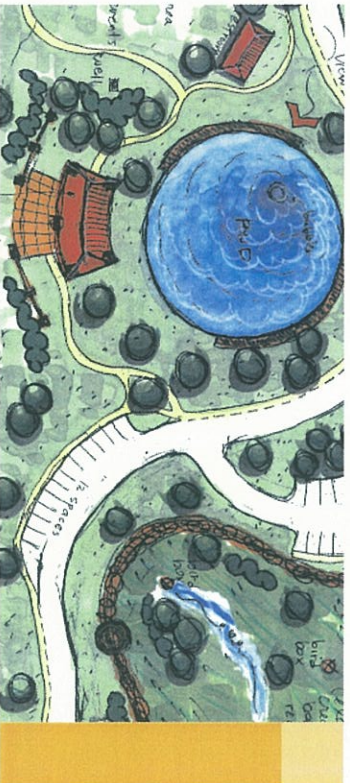
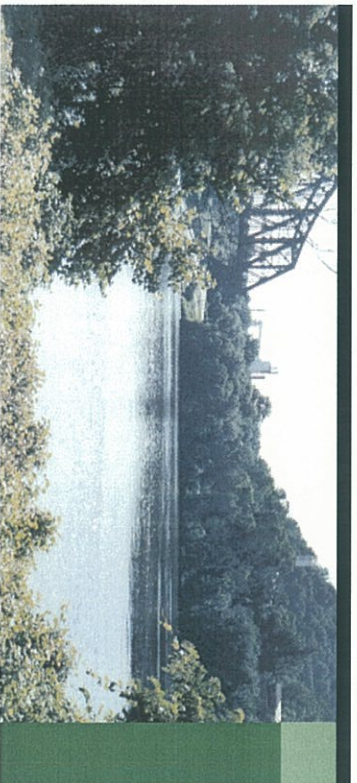
Borough of Beaver

Master Site Development Plan

BEAVER BOROUGH RIVERFRONT PARK

December 2001

This project was financed in part by a Keystone Recreation, Park and Conservation Fund Grant Program, from the Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources, Bureau of Recreation and Conservation.



Borough of Beaver

Riverfront Park Master Site Development Plan

Pashek Associates acknowledges the contributions of the following groups:

- The project study committee provided invaluable energy, dedication, and hard work.
- The citizens of Beaver contributed essential input and support.
- Beaver High School Student Council gave enthusiasm and candid input.

Study Committee Members

Beaver Borough

- John Barrett (Manager)
- Jim Foster (President of Council)
- Tom Hamilton (Council - Riverfront Development Committee)
- Fred Weigle (Council - Chairman of Recreation Committee)
- Dan McKeel (Public Works)
- Curt Frank (Chairman, Planning and Zoning Commission)
- Greg Capraro (School District Recreation Director)
- Tony Hovance (Police Chief)
- Mark Peluso (Citizen)

Bridgewater Borough

- Wayne Shaffer (Bridgewater Council)

Key Person Interview Participants

- Mike Harich
- Dennis Pittman
- Yvonne Conner
- Bill Cooper
- Alan Grim
- Joyce Lewis-Andrews
- Stacia Porter
- Ed McLaughlin
- Mark Korcinsky
- Zach Wallover
- Tom McCreary
- Bob Rimby

The Beaver County Corporation for Economic Development

- Laura Rubino (Project Manager)

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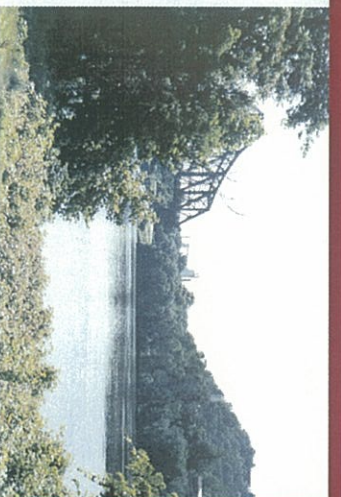
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Executive Summary

Executive Summary



Community Background

On the National Register of Historic Places, the Borough of Beaver exemplifies the ideal small town community. Numerous churches, thriving businesses, a well-respected school district, a mix of housing types, beautiful parks, and an array of community events contribute to a favorable quality of life.

The Ohio and Beaver rivers are a valuable resource to residents of Beaver and adjacent communities. Riverfront parks, in municipalities under the Beaver County Riverfront Development Program, provide a variety of services and recreational opportunities. This Master Plan concerns a twelve-acre parcel of riverfront land in Beaver Borough. The goal is to provide a unique park to serve residents and complement existing and proposed riverfront parks.

Site Analysis

The site's natural features make it ideal for use as a park. The parcel of land is level and accessible to the waters of the Ohio River, offering wonderful views. Its riparian environment and the presence of wildlife make it distinct from other Beaver parks.

The majority of the site is within the Beaver Historic District. While the Ohio River defines the southern border of the parcel, the floodway is basically confined to the bank of the river. The site is within the one hundred year flood plain.



Access to the Site occurs at two locations: in Beaver from River Road at Beaver Street (over a public railroad crossing) and through Bridgewater Crossing in Bridgewater. The site is comprised of open space, Borough maintenance facilities, a water treatment plant and water wells. A wastewater treatment plant, in Bridgewater Borough, borders the northeastern side of the site. Norfolk Southern Corporation's railroad tracks border the northern side.

Park Master Plan Process

Pashke Associates designed a process to ensure the final plan would be professionally sound and fully supported by local administrators and community members. The public input process included working sessions with a project study committee, three public meetings, a student representative meeting, and key person interviews.

Efforts of the study committee were critical to the development of the final plan. The committee included the Borough manager, the school district recreation director, and representatives from the Borough Council, public works, planning and zoning, public safety, and Beaver residents. This committee acted as a sounding board at public meetings, provided feedback on design alternatives, and reviewed recommendations.

Many individuals participated in public meetings. Through a structured process, attendees provided input about the site, desired facilities and programs, and other issues and concerns. Pashke Associates used this

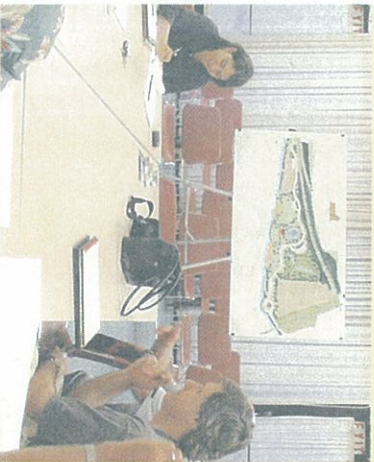
input to develop design alternatives and a preliminary suggested design. The public responded to these designs.

Individuals holding key positions in the community, identified by the study committee, were interviewed by phone. In this way, community leaders gave responses to a standard set of questions and had the opportunity to voice their concerns.

Pashke Associates grouped ideas or 'visions' consistently mentioned in the public process and utilized this information to form a vision statement for the future of the park.

Vision for the Riverfront Park

- *Design a simple park with flexible passive recreation space offering amenities for all ages, while respecting the natural environment and maintaining access to existing Borough facilities.*



- *Create a park that serves as a natural destination for wildlife and human life communities, providing a haven where birds and mammals are supported and observed as they establish or pass through.*

- *Provide a gathering place for conversation, with areas for passive recreation, as a place people can go to be revitalized by the calming river environment. Establish a park that will serve as a restorative place for relaxing and reconnecting with the natural world. Encourage an educational experience gained through personal exploration.*

- *Create this park using natural materials and a simple, flood-resistant, and easy-to-maintain design.*



Recommendations

The features of the new riverfront park flow from a balance of several key elements. The design of the park provides open lawn and trail space for recreation while expanding and enhancing the site's natural habitat. It celebrates the historical and natural features of Beaver Borough while complementing other parks within the Beaver County area. Finally, the design balances these elements in a simple, flood-resistant, and low maintenance park.

Highlights of the new park include the following improvements and additions:

Open Lawn Area

A large open area for pick-up games, community events and other gatherings will be created. A continuous stone sitting wall, bordered by a path, will define this area, and serve as a physical barrier from the park road.

Natural Habitat Area

An enlargement of the existing natural depression will provide a haven for wildlife and a viewing area for visitors. This area, with irregular edges and varying sloped banks, will support a diverse range of wildlife and vegetation species. It will also provide a means to filter stormwater and improve its quality before entering the river.

Rounded River Stone Wall

A natural, curving wall, made of local stone apparently deposited in the area during the Ice Age, will separate the natural habitat area. Educational signs will be inscribed in the wall.

Wildlife Attraction

Numerous birds and mammals will be attracted to the natural area. Bird nesting boxes and viewing posts will be added. School environmental clubs can be involved in constructing and maintaining these elements.

Community Pavilion

A large pavilion will be constructed to provide shade and winter shelter, and facilitate community gatherings. Its design will accommodate a

variety of other uses as well. Electrical outlets, emergency phone, lighting and water will be provided here. A restroom will be built near enough to the pavilion for easy access but far enough away to reduce aesthetic problems. Natural material will be used in the construction of the pavilion and restroom.

Trails and Connections

Pedestrian trails will accommodate walking, biking, and roller-blading. At two points, trails of this park will connect to adjacent Bridgewater Crossing. One of these points will eventually join the existing (and future proposed) boardwalk at Bridgewater's Bicentennial Park.

Pond/Water Feature

A shallow 165' diameter pond will provide a focal point for the park as well as a place for summer wading and winter skating. A fountain or spray feature may be included.

River Access

Seated viewing areas and a "river walk" will be created along the riverfront, with precautions taken to protect the walkway from flood damage. Tie-up locations will allow boaters access to the park. Boaters and other visitors will enjoy a sandy beach constructed to require limited maintenance in case of flooding. A fishing platform will be added at the river's edge.

Art

Incorporation of art will contribute to a unique sense of place. Art can serve as focal points, such as a lighthouse or wildlife sculpture. Design competitions can be initiated to elicit creative solutions and encourage public participation in the park design.

Plantings

Large trees for shade and wildlife shelter will be planted at the edge of the natural habitat area, more closely where needed to screen the sewage treatment plant. A mixture of native plants will enhance beauty and provide food and shelter for wildlife. Community garden plots for vegetables and flowers will be incorporated into the natural habitat area. In some areas, underbrush and lesser trees will be removed to open views to the river.

Maintenance Facilities and Access

For the near future, most facilities will remain at their current location. The salt storage shed will be replaced and relocated. Current structures will be painted a neutral color to blend with the park environment.

Parking and Paving

Existing park entrance, exit, and one-lane roads will be enhanced. The public railroad track crossing will be upgraded for safety. A new access road will curve through the site, allowing views of the river. Convenient parking will be located near each activity area.

Implementation

A detailed cost estimate was prepared. Park improvements were divided into seven distinct phases to reflect a logical progression of construction. Per the requirements of the DCNR, the total estimated phase costs reflect prices as if each phase was a contracted project. With volunteer labor and donated materials, costs may be less than estimated.

The seven project phases are as follows:

- Safe Site Access \$504,400
- Site Preparation \$540,675
- Initial Site Improvements \$724,000
- River's Edge Improvements and Natural Habitat \$732,350
- Restroom \$280,975
- Community Pavilion \$505,750
- Pond/Water Feature \$279,975
- Total Cost \$3,568,125

The final chapter of the report contains potential funding sources for proposed park improvements.



Recommended Plan



Introduction

Introduction



The Borough of Beaver, in its efforts to expand recreational opportunities for its residents and their families, has undertaken a master planning process for its only parcel of land accessible to the waters of the Ohio River. Improvements to this parcel are intended to be a valuable asset to the community and to provide families with a place to enjoy the river environment.

In June 2001, Beaver Borough received a grant through DCNR's Keystone Recreation, Park, and Conservation Fund grant program to fund a Master Site Development Plan for a twelve-acre parcel of land along the Ohio River. Subsequently, Pashek Associates, Ltd., a firm of landscape architects, and recreation and community planners, was retained to assist the Borough and the community in preparing the plan. The Beaver County Corporation for Economic Development (BCCED) managed the project, ensuring the Plan was complimentary to the vision of the Beaver County Riverfront Development Plan prepared in 1993.

The purpose of this Master Site Development Plan for the Beaver Borough Riverfront Park is to provide ideas on how the land should be developed consistent with its natural context, and in a way that will provide enjoyment to its users. The Plan forms a foundation to guide decision making for the park's future development. The vision and recommended design developed in this Plan will serve as a basis for the next step in the design process, to prepare construction documents for the park and to obtain funding for its development.

As the project gains momentum, this Plan will provide the Borough with the tool to respond to various organizations and individuals who may express an interest in contributing to the development of the site. Following the recommendations developed in this planning process will ensure the park meets the needs and desires expressed by the Beaver Borough community.

*Parks and recreation
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communities.*

Process

The master planning process involved an analysis of the site's natural and cultural resources, generation of possible ideas for its development, and an estimate of construction costs. A series of input meetings were held with the community and the study committee to ensure the public's voice was heard. Through this input process, a vision was identified and the Master Site Development Plan for the Beaver Borough Riverfront Park was developed. It represents a culmination of the desires of those involved in the master planning process.

The Benefits of Parks and Recreation

Parks and recreation play a critical role in providing a high quality of life to communities. Environmental benefits include preserving habitat and wildlife, protecting ecosystems, and reducing pollutants. Community benefits include providing places to relax and engage in community gatherings, and providing residents of all ages the opportunity to enjoy nature. Economic benefits include attracting businesses and their employees to the area, increasing land and property values, and boosting tourism.

With Beaver County reporting a decrease in population in the latest census, offering an opportunity to enhance quality of life is key. A recent article in the local paper further supported the importance of recreation, as County Commissioner Charlie Camp recognized: "It's part of the complete package that we have to offer to be competitive (in

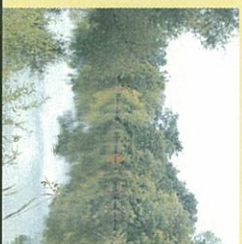
attracting businesses and residents). Recreation can't just be an afterthought anymore.....Whether it's green space in a business park or housing plan, or a trail, or a rock-climbing wall, it's the kind of thing we need to be able to sell Beaver County." The County's residents agreed, prioritizing riverfront districts and the development of walking and biking trails.

The Beaver County Corporation for Economic Development has been leading the way in Riverfront development over the last decade. With the initiation of the Beaver County Riverfront Development Program in 1993 (in which Beaver is among nine other participating municipalities), the Corporation's goal is to provide economic and recreational benefits to both participating and neighboring communities. Each community's riverfront land, whether along the Ohio River, Beaver River, or one of its tributaries, presents a variety of opportunities. The goal is to develop each to be complementary, providing the most variety of facilities and recreation to area residents.

The Riverfront Development Plan included the following recommendations for the site under this study: "Much of this land is undeveloped, however the limited access to this area and the nature of the

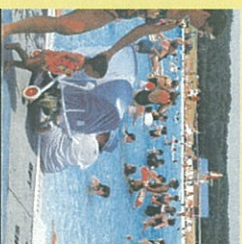
Environmental Benefits

- Preserves habitat and wildlife
- Protects ecosystems
- Reduces pollutants



Economic Benefits

- Attracts businesses and their employees
- Increases land and property values
- Boosts tourism



BENEFITS OF RECREATION, PARKS & OPEN SPACE

Community Benefits

- Provides spaces for community gatherings
- Provides residents a place to enjoy nature



Personal Benefits

- Creates a balance between work and play
- Reduces stress
- Eliminates boredom and loneliness



existing public uses would begin to suggest that any further development of this site be limited to passive recreation or other low impact uses which preserve beneficial floodplain values."

The future development of the Beaver Borough Riverfront Park will benefit the community and the area by contributing to the recreation opportunities available to residents, and be consistent with the goals identified in the Beaver County Riverfront Development Program. The park will be developed in a passive manner which will allow recreational opportunities to coexist with the protected riparian ecosystem.

Document Organization

Introduction

The content of this Plan conforms to the requirements for a Master Site Development Plan as defined by DCNR's Bureau of Conservation and Recreation. The Plan is organized in the following manner:

Executive Summary

Introduction

Chapter 1: Inventory and Analysis

This chapter briefly describes Beaver Borough's history, culture, recreation, and people. It also describes an analysis of the opportunities and constraints of the site for use as a park. This information provides a context from which this Park Master Plan was based.

Chapter 2: Public Participation

Public input was a key component in the development of the Plan. This chapter describes the public participation process and summary results from each venue of participation. The input culminates in the identification of vision elements and the development of a Vision for the park.

Chapter 3: Schematic Design Alternatives

This portion of the document presents schematic design ideas generated, including the Preliminary Design for the park.

Chapter 4: Recommended Design

This chapter describes the Recommended Design elements for inclusion in the Beaver Borough Riverfront Park Master Site Development Plan.

Chapter 5: Implementation

The final chapter presents estimated development costs for each anticipated phase of construction and suggests possible funding sources for development.

Appendix

Included in the Appendix are supporting reference materials for use in the implementation of Plan recommendations. This document is under separate cover.

Chapter 1

Inventory and Analysis



Chapter 1

Inventory and Analysis

Introduction to the Community

Geographic Location

The Borough of Beaver, Pennsylvania, is located in Beaver County approximately thirty miles northwest of the City of Pittsburgh, along the northern bank of the Ohio River where it makes its juncture with the Beaver River. The County is bordered by Lawrence County to the north, Allegheny and Washington Counties to the south, and Butler County to the east. Its western side is bordered by the States of Ohio and West Virginia.

The existing highway network provides residents with easy access within Western Pennsylvania and into Ohio. State Route 60 is located just west of the Borough and provides direct access to Pittsburgh and its International Airport, along with large regional shopping and employment destinations in North Fayette, Moon, and Robinson Townships. Route 60 also provides access to the Pennsylvania and Ohio turnpikes.

State Routes 65 and 51 are located just east of the Borough and also provide connections to downtown Pittsburgh and the regional interstate system. State Route 68 is a main east-west corridor, joining many surrounding routes and bisecting the central business district in Beaver Borough.

The Borough's residents enjoy the benefits of small-town living, with easy access to the City of Pittsburgh. The City offers residents nationally recognized cultural and sporting events, first-class healthcare and educational facilities, and recreational opportunities.

*The Borough's
residents enjoy the
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Pittsburgh.*

Community History

Beaver is one of Western Pennsylvania's most historic and culturally rich communities.

Its location on the river as well as on the route of the Great Trail (a main westward path) encouraged settlement. Fort McIntosh was established by General Lachlan McIntosh (appointed by General George Washington) in his efforts to defend the western frontier. Later, this Fort became the first home of the United States Army.

The original town built by the French during the French and Indian War was named King Beaver's Town in honor of a Delaware Indian leader. The town was laid out on a grid system, with four quadrants dedicated to public parks in the center, along with one at each of the four corners of town. In the late 1700's, this new town on the Beaver Plateau, then called Beavertown, was created. In 1802, Beaver was incorporated as a municipal Borough.

The 1800's brought many changes to Beaver, including the construction of the town's third Court House, the formation of the Beaver College and Musical Institute for Women, and the construction of the Beaver County Jail. Operation of the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad provided connections to Pittsburgh, establishing Beaver as a desirable bedroom community.



The original eight parks within the town were named after prominent figures in Beaver's history:

1. **Agnew Square**, Judge Daniel Agnew, Chief Justice of the Pennsylvania Supreme Court.
2. **Boquet Park**, Colonel Henry Boquet, British Army officer who freed captive settlers.
3. **Clark Park**, Colonel George Rogers Clark, negotiated the Treaty of Fort McIntosh in 1785.
4. **Irvine Square**, across from Quay Square, was named in honor of General William Irvine who commanded the Western Department, which administered Fort McIntosh. A memorial was placed here to honor veterans of World War II.
5. **McIntosh Square**, General Lachlan McIntosh, appointed by General George Washington, established Fort McIntosh in an effort to defend the western frontier.
6. **Quay Square**, Mathew Stanley Quay, 1887 United States Senator and head of the Republican Party.
7. **Wayne Park**, General Anthony Wayne, brought peace to the area by defeating the Indians in the Battle of Fallen Timbers.
8. **Linn Park**, Mayor Robert P. Linn, current Beaver Mayor spanning a half century of service.

Today, Beaver is a quaint residential village known for its Borough parks, tree-lined streets, and architecturally significant homes. Its thriving retail business district and numerous community events establish Beaver as an attraction within central Beaver County. In addition, it is home to County government offices.

Population and Size

Beaver Borough has a current resident population of 4,775. Since 1990, the Borough experienced a five percent decrease in population; however, with the Borough encompassing approximately one square mile, it remains the densest municipality in the region.

Age distribution of Borough residents reveals:

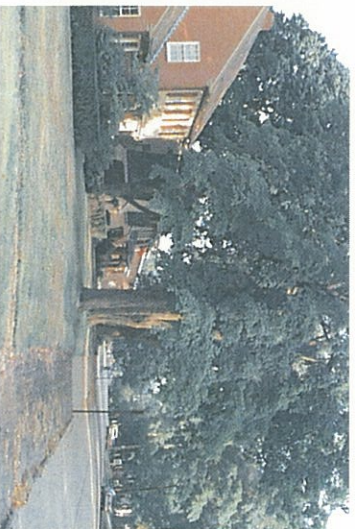
- 1018 youth 19 and under (21.32 percent);
- 222 between the ages of 20-24 (4.65 percent);
- 1275 between the ages of 25 and 44 (26.70 percent);
- 1206 between the ages of 45 and 54 (25.26 percent);
- 1054 over 65 (22.07 percent).

Land Use

The predominant use of land in Beaver is residential, including single and multi-family, offering housing choices to many people regardless of age, income, or family size. The balance of the land is used by offices, commercial, and neighborhood retail establishments. These are generally concentrated along or adjacent to the central Third Street corridor, a traditional Main Street.

This main street and its immediate environs are a tremendous resource to the community. They provide access to local goods and services, and define a community core area and sense of place. The Beaver County Courthouse is situated in the center of town, on one of the original quadrant squares.

All of the original town, and most portions of the present Borough were designated the Beaver Historic District. The majority of land area of the Riverfront site in which this study encompasses is included within this District. Beaver's 317-acre historic district was listed on the National Register of Historic Places in the fall of 1996. The National Register recognizes places that have made a significant contribution to our country's heritage.



Beaver Borough Park System

Recreation and open space is at the core of Borough history. In addition to the many Borough parks, wide street rights-of-way contribute to the abundance of public green space. Mature shade trees line many of these rights-of-way.

The Beaver municipal park system includes twelve parks totaling approximately 44.5 acres of public land. This acreage falls within the recommended acreage per resident population and is located within the proper spatial distribution, as represented in the National Recreation and Parks Association (NRPA) guidelines.

Recreation and open space facilities in each of the Borough's parks include the following:

Center Quadrant Parks:

(each is two and one-half acres in size)

QUAY SQUARE

(bounded by Third, Market, Turnpike, and Insurance Streets)

Contains a monument honoring local service personnel serving in Vietnam, and a stage for concerts and events.

IRVINE SQUARE

(across Third Street from Quay Square)

A memorial was placed to honor veterans of World War II. The square was named in honor of General William Irvine who commanded the Western Department, which administered Fort McIntosh. A large gazebo graces the center of this park, and is used for weddings and other such events.

MCINTOSH SQUARE

(across Third Street from Agnew Square)

A tall soldier's monument was erected in the center of this park to honor those who died in the Civil War. Walkways and lawn areas with mature trees complete this park.

AGNEW SQUARE

(bounded by Turnpike, Third, Commerce, and Market Streets)

Although one of the original four center quadrant parks, the Beaver County Courthouse is located here.

Perimeter Quadrant Parks:

(each is two and one-half acres in size)

BOQUET PARK

(Beaver Street and Fifth Street)

Playground includes equipment and an open space lawn area for pick-up games. The perimeter of the park is graced with large shade trees.

CLARK PARK CEMETERY

(Buffalo Street and Fifth Street)

A monument acknowledging burial grounds stands in the center of this park. Tree-lined walkways and open space lawn area completes this park.

WAYNE PARK

(River Road and Beaver Street)

Offers views of the Ohio River and is very picturesque, as its edges are defined by large shade trees and stately homes. A large open lawn area for pick-up games, a small sledding hill, and playground equipment are located in this park.

LINN PARK

(on River Road at Buffalo Street)

Features include playground equipment and an open lawn area with shade trees.

Remaining Parks

ROOSEVELT PARK

(across Fifth Street from Boquet Park)

Referred to the Water Lot, the land was designated a park to protect a spring originally used as a water source for the community. This two and one-half acre parcel, named after Theodore Roosevelt, is undeveloped but for the remnants of an arched roof sandstone structure shielding the spring. A small wooded area and stream occur above the structure. The site serves as a popular sledding hill.

GYPSY GLEN PARK

(along Gypsy Glen Road at the northwest corner of the Borough)

The Senior High School and the Middle School are located adjacent to this four-acre parcel. Classified as a community park, the site contains

tennis courts, a pavilion, a multi-use field, and the swimming pool and bathhouse. Gypsy Glen Park is the site of the annual Beaver Borough Community Picnic.

RIVERVIEW PARK

(along the length of River Road)

The six acre linear park, which includes the Fort McIntosh Historic Site, extends the entire length of the Borough. The passive park includes open lawn and shaded areas as well as benches from which visitors enjoy panoramic views of the Ohio River. Numerous privately maintained flowerbeds and many flowering ornamental trees add to its beauty.

RIVERFRONT OPEN SPACE AREA

(at the southeast corner of the Borough)

The twelve acre parcel covered in this study.

Other Riverfront Recreation Opportunities

The Ohio and Beaver Rivers provide numerous recreation opportunities for area residents. Popular activities include recreational boating and other water activities, fishing, entertainment and river viewing. The Beaver County Flag Plaza was erected along the banks of the Beaver River in Rochester's Riverfront Park. The plaza was built in association with Flags Across America, a national non-profit organization. A County Riverfest and other river-related public events are also held annually.

Riverfront parks in municipalities under the Beaver County Riverfront Development Program, as well as other riverfront communities, provide the following existing and proposed recreational opportunities:

Bridgewater Borough Riverfront on the Beaver River offers marinas, restaurants, and courtesy docks. Its Bicentennial Park contains a boardwalk for walking and fishing, an extended walkway with benches, an amphitheater, and an observation deck. Access to Bridgewater Borough from Beaver is accomplished via a pedestrian trail which traverses under a railroad bridge near the Beaver Area Historical Museum.

Center Township is proposing a scenic overlook attraction at the Wagner Road area, to capitalize on panoramic vistas of the Ohio River Valley from this bluff high above the river.

Park Location



Beaver Borough
Park System

Chapter 1
Inventory and Analysis

BEAVER BOROUGH
Parks, Recreation & Open Space

